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If you asked us to sum up *Diablo III* in one line, here's what we would say: it's an average game that you should play, at least once.

For the uninitiated, *Diablo III*, like most other games, can be played in both single-player and multi-player modes. However, unlike most other games, even the single-player mode requires a constant internet connection. Blizzard has shed light on the reasoning behind this countless number of times but let's be honest: it's DRM and it's a particularly stupid form of DRM that turned off many *Diablo* fans.

To Blizzard's credit, we didn't face the connection issues that racked the game's launch, even once. We picked the EU servers to play and soon had a monk, named 'Drona,' off and running, punching monsters to death. The first hour or so, went off fine. Zombies exploded in chunks of gore and gristle, skeletons shattered into piles of ivory white bone and Drona plodded on, occasionally spouting fantasy-speak in a Russian accent. The first big issue we noticed was that there just wasn't enough good loot. Our monk was predominantly relying on fist weapons (think knuckle-dusters) and for almost three hours, we didn't come across even one fist weapon. Every once in a while,

our inventory would fill up and we would teleport back to town to sell it all. Soon, we had a lot of gold, but none of the merchants had anything worth buying so we just spent it all trying to upgrade at the town blacksmith. We had never engaged in any trading with other players in the previous games, and we thought we wouldn't need to do so this time around. But after three hours of just not getting good loot, we logged out of the game and logged in to the Auction House. It was magnificent, at first. We saw fist weapons, six times as powerful as the ones we had, being sold for meagre amounts of gold and we just couldn't get enough of shopping. But soon we realized the gaping flaw in all of this: why weren't we having this much fun in the game?

We started playing the game again and although it's paced very well (in terms of gameplay, not plot- there's hardly a plot to speak of). It's always pushing you ahead. The Auction House remained at the back of our mind, urging us to play a sort of mini-game, something we not only didn't care for, but which also, completely destroyed any semblance of immersion that the game had created. Four "Acts" later, our monk – now level 32, destroyed *Diablo* in a surprisingly easy fight and we knew we didn't want to play as him again, at least for a long time. Again, *Diablo III* is not a bad game. The clever changes to

the character skill systems and the way it pushes the action forward are testament to that fact. So are the professional movie-quality cinematics, sound design and slick interface. And that makes it worth playing, at least once. But most of all, and we say this keeping in mind the hours we've spent playing *Diablo II*: it's quite forgettable. ★

Verdict

If you're a fan of action-RPG click-fests, then you owe it to yourself to pick up *Diablo III*. However, if you've played the previous *Diablo* games, keep your expectations in check and you'll enjoy the game. If you're not a fan, then *Diablo III* won't do much to make you one.

MOAR!

- » **Developer:** Blizzard Entertainment
- » **Publisher:** Blizzard Entertainment
- » **Platforms:** PC Exclusive

